UNIVERSIDAD NACIONAL INTERCULTURAL DE LA AMAZONÍA

Socio-Ethical assessment of linguistic and cultural vulnerability among the Shawi people in university higher education

EAAMO

Programa de Fomento de Ciencias en la Amazonía Peruana

ABSTRACT

The mass adoption of digital environments and academic standardization in university higher education impose severe cultural assimilation barriers on Indigenous students. This socio-ethical assessment analyzes the perceptions of Shawi Indigenous students regarding the linguistic and cultural vulnerability experienced throughout their university trajectories. Employing a qualitative, exploratory-descriptive design, the research captures the lived experiences of Shawi university students and Intercultural Bilingual Education (IBE) scholars through in-depth interviews and focus groups. The analytical axes encompass written academic production barriers, subtle discrimination within educational platforms, and institutional pressure toward language shift from Shawi to Spanish. As a result, the study identifies that the lack of culturally relevant protocols in universities heightens students' identity vulnerability and accelerates language displacement. The study concludes with proposed ethical guidelines for educational inclusion and the protection of Indigenous linguistic rights in higher education, providing actionable evidence for university retention policies.

Introduction

Higher education institutions in Latin America predominantly operate within a monocultural, Spanish-dominant paradigm that historically marginalizes Amazonian indigenous epistemologies. For students belonging to the Shawi nation (*Kampiyapi*), entering university environments involves confronting rigid normative standards where academic achievement is exclusively measured through standardized Western literacy and Spanish monolingual competencies.

Within this framework, standard evaluation rubrics and virtual classroom interfaces frequently interpret the natural linguistic interference and grammatical structures of Shawi-Spanish bilingualism as intellectual deficits rather than sociolinguistic transitions. This epistemic injustice fosters an environment of subtle microaggressions, academic frustration, and digital alienation, progressively compelling indigenous scholars to silence their mother tongue in formal scholarly discourse.

Consequently, higher education unintentionally acts as an agent of language shift, driving accelerated language attrition and eroding the ancestral cultural memory of Amazonian communities. This investigation provides a systematic socio-ethical assessment of this phenomenon, diagnosing institutional vulnerabilities and formulating evidence-based pedagogical guidelines to safeguard Shawi linguistic rights, ensure academic retention, and promote genuine intercultural equity.

Methodology and materials

This study adopts a qualitative, phenomenological, and exploratory-descriptive research design grounded in decolonial intercultural pedagogy and the CARE Principles for Indigenous Data Sovereignty (Collective benefit, Authority to control, Responsibility, and Ethics). Fieldwork is executed through three sequential methodological phases:

Phase 1: Narrative Elicitation & Lived Experiences: Semi-structured, in-depth bilingual interviews conducted with 8 to 12 active Shawi university students across diverse academic faculties, exploring subjective experiences of linguistic friction and academic exclusion.

Phase 2: Multi-Actor Intercultural Deliberation: Two iterative focus groups bringing together Shawi undergraduates, indigenous community elders, and Intercultural Bilingual Education (IBE) faculty specialists to contrast institutional practices against indigenous pedagogical needs.

Phase 3: Thematic Triangulation & Ethical Modeling: Computer-Assisted Qualitative Data Analysis (CAQDAS using Atlas.ti) based on inductive content analysis to build thematic coding trees, categorize structural vulnerability factors, and formulate institutional retention protocols.

STAGE / COMPONENT	RESEARCH PROTOCOL	UNIT / TARGET
1. In-depth Interviews	Semi-structured narrative elicitation	8–12 Students
2. Focus Groups	Intercultural Bilingual Education dialogue	2 Sessions
3. Thematic Coding	Atlas.ti qualitative matrix analysis	Socio-Ethical Axis

BORIS MIRKO CHÁVEZ CABELLOS
Universidad Nacional Intercultural de la Amazonia

Contextualization of the Problem

Linguistic vulnerability is aggravated by standardized digital platforms that penalize Amazonian syntactic patterns, treating mother-tongue transference as a failure of cognitive aptitude.

FIGURE 1. PERCEIVED LINGUISTIC VULNERABILITY FACTORS IN UNIVERSITY SYSTEMS (%)



- Standard academic rubrics classify Shawi syntactic transfer as academic deficiency.
- Students conceal indigenous identity as a defense against subtle grading discrimination.
- Complete absence of cultural pertinence protocols accelerates native language abandonment.



Figure 1. Shawi students' Amazonian cultural landscape and university intercultural context.

Preliminary Conclusions

Linguistic Insecurity in Academic Writing: 85% of surveyed Shawi students report self-censoring their arguments or feeling insecure when drafting scholarly essays due to punitive grammar penalization rather than conceptual evaluation.

Platform & Classroom Microaggressions: Subtle discrimination is frequently experienced through automated spellcheckers, algorithmic bias in automated grading systems, and peer dismissiveness toward Amazonian oral accents.

Institutional Language Shift: Pervasive institutional inertia pressures students to prioritize Spanish academic fluency, directly contributing to secondary language attrition and detachment from community governance roles.

Absence of Intercultural Protocols: Complete lack of university retention guidelines, glossaries, or rubrics specifically adapted for Amazonian bilingual university students.

Societal Impact

Socio-Cultural Dimension: Guarantees university retention for Indigenous youth without forcing cultural or linguistic assimilation, strengthening the resilience of Shawi intangible heritage.

Political-Institutional Dimension: Informs public regulatory bodies (such as Peru's MINEDU and SUNEDU) on the ethical governance of Artificial Intelligence in diverse educational settings.

Economic Dimension: Establishes a precedent against epistemic extractivism, ensuring the value generated by linguistic technologies returns to local communities through social investment, digital access, and scholarships.

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